

HIT PARADE Vaibhav in action against SRH in the IPL semi-final eliminator match. He hit 97 off 29 balls

has exploded with such precocious authority in the Indian Premier League (IPL) that the game is still adjusting, almost in real time, to the arrival of the phenomenon.

It's hard to believe that the southpaw is still only 15. The 2026 IPL was only his second season, but the figures are absurd enough already—the unbeaten 103 against Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH), the back-to-back 90s (97 in just 29 balls again against SRH again, and 97 in 47 balls against Gujarat Titans in the play-offs). In 16 matches for Rajasthan Royals (RR) this season, he amassed 776 runs at an average of 48.50 and a mind-boggling strike rate of 237.30, finishing with the Orange Cap as the tournament's top run-scorer. He struck 72 sixes—the most by any batter in a single IPL season—surpassing a record that had long seemed inseparable from the West Indian six-machine Chris Gayle's mythology.

In 2025, RR had bought him for Rs 1.1 crore, and almost immediately the tournament was forced to adjust its sense of scale. Vaibhav launched the very first delivery he faced in the competition for six and then, against Gujarat Titans, scored 101 off 38 balls at the age of 14 years and 32 days, becoming the youngest centurion in men's T20 cricket. The hundred came in just 35 balls, the second-fastest in IPL history, behind only Gayle's assault for Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) against Pune Warriors in 2013. RR soon realised that they had not simply bought a teenager, they had bought a teen tornado.

TRAINING GROUND FOR A PRODIGY

Tajpur, in Samastipur district of north Bihar, has open fields and roads and the sort of unhurried horizon from which few expect a cricketer of national consequence to emerge. Yet, this is where Vaibhav began training at the age of four. By 2018, when he was just seven, father Sanjeev had seen enough promise to get his young son enrolled at Manish Ojha's GenNex Cricket Academy in Patna. The family then began the kind of grind that would exhaust most adults, let alone a child: 175 km from Samastipur to Patna and back on alternate days for practice, often in a vehicle carrying not just the father and son, but even net bowlers brought along to bowl to him.

"To play in all directions of the ground, you need good wrist work. Vaibhav isn't slogging, he's just picking the line and length earlier than most, clearing the rope comfortably"
—Sachin Tendulkar

Sanjeev had little interest in conventional "group training". He wanted something more focused, more demanding, handcrafted around his son's talent. Ojha, a former Bihar and Jharkhand cricketer, recalls that when Vaibhav first arrived, he was so small that a bouncer would simply have sailed over his head. The first phase of training, therefore, began with underarm throw-downs. The objective was not power but balance, timing and the discipline of watching the ball from the instant it left the hand. Two years later, as Vaibhav gained height and strength, they shifted him to cement pitches, where the hard surface produced steeper bounce and pace.

Eventually, the academy introduced sidearm throwers, the slingshot-like training implement used in modern cricket coaching to hurl a cricket ball at speeds of up to 150 kmph with precision. The workload bordered on obsessiveness. Ojha says Vaibhav would often face 600 deliveries in a single day. If the coaches grew tired, the support staff took over. If they tired, the accompanying net bowlers stepped in. Sessions went on till the boy had exhausted every variation thrown at him.